

1st International Student Shorts Film Festival

The Big Picture

What? The 1st International Student Shorts Film Festival is a free, easy-to-access online opportunity. Films housed on YouTube.

Who? A coalition of willing students, schools, and performing, broadcasting, and film artists throughout the world (Year 7/Grade 6 – Year 13/Grade 12).

Where? Film Festival will occur online, and films will be shot and produced in locations throughout the World.

When? Student submissions due on THURSDAY, May 8 at Midnight (within the respective school's time zone). International winners announced on May 23 and 24.

How? Students will work individually or in student production teams via class or extra-curricular activity.

Why? Because student voice and creativity should be cultivated, amplified, and celebrated. All benefit: the older generations and the students themselves.

International Film Festival Details

Who will serve as official film festival jurors? Judges will include distinguished journalists, authors, actors, musicians, artists, dancers, chefs, poets, scriptwriters, casting agents, film critics, theatre and film directors, producers, editors, animators, broadcasters, political commentators, academicians, leaders in artificial intelligence and NGOs and more.

What sorts of short films may students submit to the festival? The film festival consists of twelve categories with fiction and nonfiction options. They are the following:

My AI AI focused. Fiction or nonfiction. Any genre. Any film festival category. NO AI generated films will be accepted.

My Animation Fiction or nonfiction. Any genre. Any film festival category. Claymation & Lego stop motion included.

My Art Arts and crafts (sculpting, painting, photography, drawing, etc...). Could be time-lapse video.

My Audition Display of acting prowess as if in front of casting. May include showreel of acting within short films.

My Dance Production highlighting any and all forms of dance and choreography, i.e. ballet, contemporary, hip hop, tap, folk, swing, ballroom, Irish, Bollywood, Latin, disco, polka, tango, break, etc.

My Experience Convey distinctive or problematic aspects of life in HOME country, region, city/village, or school. Autobiographical or Citizen journalism.

My Food Cooking or baking show; new recipe; restaurant review; plant food; food implications (religious, geographic, ethnic, environmental, health).

My Music Production highlighting student singing and (or) instrumentals.

My Poetry Highlighting poem written by member of production team.

My Shorts A short fictional story or scene (possibly intertextual or based on a real-life event). Any genre.

My Trailer Trailer to a proposed movie that a student wants to produce or see produced. Any genre.

My Voice Address social, political, and (or) economic issue and suggest ways of tackling it OR share inspirational advocacy or humanitarian work being done by students at school.

Additional details on each category can be found on pages 2 through 4. They provide a glimpse into how films will be placed and assessed. No one movie can be placed in more than two categories.

How does a participating school determine which student films should be submitted to the Student Shorts Film Festival? Each school develops its own process for determining which films will move to the Student Shorts Film Festival (maximum of three films per category per school). Submissions must be done at some point between Sunday, January 7, and Thursday, May 9. This will be via a Google Form which will be made available on December 7.

What's the required timeframe for film production? Any films produced between September 1 (2024) and immediately prior to the submission deadline of May 8 (2025) are eligible for submission.

What if a finalist submission does not achieve 1st, 2nd, or 3rd? Does that mean it will not receive any award or special recognition? Two answers. First, all contenders will receive a digital "Finalists Certificate". The final blue-ribbon jury will also announce a variety of additional awards not mentioned in the judging process description. Categories may include "Most Novel", "More with Less", "Best Actor", etc...

Will junior high/middle school students be competing with their senior high counterparts? No. Middle/JH students will compete separately from SH students. However, the film festival does not oppose some vertical diversity in student

production teams. While every film must be submitted either in the JH/Middle or SH category, the following combinations would be permissible:

A. Junior high, KS3, middle school students may serve as major or minor actors as well as secondary crew members in SENIOR HIGH productions. Adults may play minor acting roles.

B. Senior high students may play secondary roles as actors and/or crewmembers in JUNIOR HIGH productions. Adults may also play minor acting roles.

Will winners receive prizes? Up to the judges, but they have donated in previous student film festivals. Can't promise. This is an unfunded labour of love.

Will each school's student videos be made available to the public? We hope that each school submits as many films as possible to the web platform of the The 1st International Student Shorts Film Festival . Student production teams themselves will determine whether their names are included in their film credits or YouTube titles. Needless to say, the more films available, the more enriching the experience for all participants.

What are the rules and guidelines for submitted films?

THE DO'S

- All films must represent original work by the members of each production team.
- All films must be 2 minutes or less. All others will be disqualified.
- All films must be produced primarily by secondary students (KS3, middle school, junior and senior high).
- All submissions to the international festival on or before May 8 and must include an Image Release Form (available on request and will be linked to upcoming official film festival website).
- All films that utilize 3rd -party music must clear this with the original owners/license holders. Copyright and Fair Use laws must be respected.
- All films may include names of student production team members; however, all films must include the name of the responsible Production Team and school represented.

THE DON'TS

- No submission may contain any third-party work, INCLUDING ANY MUSICAL RECORDING OR COMPOSITION, unless (1) Production Team has a license to use such work in the submission from the owners/licensors; (2) such work is in the public domain. Remember, the spirit of this festival is the amplification of original creativity and personal voices.
- No submission may contain pornography or obscene content.
- No submission may infringe on a third party's intellectual property/privacy rights.
- No submission may contain any form of hate speech (based on gender, gender orientation, ethnicity, race, religion, nationality, etc.)

What if a submission does not adhere to the rules and guidelines of this film festival? If the international film festival organizers are aware of a submission that has not adhered to the above stated rules and guidelines, that submission will be eliminated from the competition. However, if time allows and the violation was accidental, festival organizers will attempt to provide the Production Team an opportunity to resubmit their film.

What will serve as the web platform for the May 2025 final round? Official Film Festival YouTube Page.

FILM FESTIVAL CATEGORY DETAILS

My Animation

Defined: Fiction or nonfiction. Any genre on any film festival topic. Could also be Claymation or Lego stop motion. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance, and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: artistic construction, screenplay, sound, camera angles, editing, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of characterization(s), singing, rapping, movement, voiceovers, and artistry.

Content: Cohesion, originality, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My AI

Defined: Fiction or nonfiction. Must be focused on AI – its functions and/or effects or potential effects. Any genre on any film festival topic. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance, and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: artistic construction, screenplay, sound, camera angles, editing, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of characterization(s), narrating, acting, singing, rapping, movement, voiceovers, and artistry.

Content: Cohesion, originality, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Art

Defined: Arts and crafts (sculpting, painting, photography, drawing, etc...). This may be fiction or nonfiction and include such options as monologues, dialogues, interviews, docudramas, stop motion, accelerated motion, musicals, raps, PowerPoints, etc. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance, and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, editing, camera work, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Arts, crafts, clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Audition

Defined: Display of acting talent skill as if in front of casting. This may be done in any genre based and based on any script or scripts. Videos may include multiple segments and narrative explanations. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation and performance.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, editing, camera work, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

My Dance

Defined: Production highlighting student dance. A chance to portray talent and skill. This may be fiction or nonfiction. Animation is acceptable. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, camera work, editing, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, dance, instrumental, any other in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Experience

Defined: Glimpse of where and how a student lives (could be in the context of family, school, community, culture, or political entity). May be fiction, non-fiction, or autobiographical, and include such options as monologues, dialogues, interviews, docudramas, dramatization, musicals, raps, animation, PowerPoints, etc. May also convey problematic aspects about life in HOME country, region, city/village, or school. May include citizen journalism. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, editing, camera work, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Food

Defined: Cooking - baking show; new recipe; restaurant review; plane food; religious, geographic, environmental, ethnic, or health factors in relation to food. This may be fiction or nonfiction. Animation is acceptable. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance, and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, camera work, editing, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Music

Defined: Production highlighting student singing and (or) instrumentals. A chance to portray talent and skill. This may be fiction or nonfiction. Animation is acceptable. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, camera work, editing, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, song, instrumental, any other in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Poetry

Defined: Fiction/Nonfiction. Must be original, highlighting a poem written by a member of the production team. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, editing, camera work, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Story

Defined: Student's original story. Any genre. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, editing, camera work, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Trailer

Defined: Trailer to a movie that a student wants to produce or see produced. This may be fiction or nonfiction and include such options as monologues, dialogues, interviews, docudramas, dramatizations, musicals, raps, animation, PowerPoints, etc... Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, editing, camera work, and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

My Voice

Defined: Problem or challenge or need that a student feels passionate about addressing (being part of a solution/ making a positive change). Address social, political, and (or) economic issue and suggest ways of tackling it OR share inspirational advocacy or humanitarian work being done by student(s) at school. This may include such options as monologues, dialogues, interviews, dramatizations, docudramas, musicals, raps, animation, PowerPoints, etc. Judging criteria will consider overall presentation, performance and content.

Presentation: Reflecting on general quality of production (with consideration given to level of technology used - phones are acceptable). Under consideration: directing, set, sound, camera work, editing and other aspects.

Performance: Quality of voice-over narration, in-front-of-camera communication & artistry.

Content: Clarity of message, originality, cohesion, relevancy, insightfulness, and cleverness.

25 of the 2025 International Student Shorts Film Festival Platinum Jury (Random Sampling)

Andrew Bossone, Field Producer, NBC News (New York)
bossonemedia

Bill Pruitt, Producer, Original Films (Malibu)

Catherine Eby, Company Manager, The Joffrey Ballet (Chicago)
<https://joffrey.org/>

Clark Jackson, Actor on "The Code" at CBS Television (New York)
clarkjacksononline

Emma Boyle, Journalist, Financial Times (London)
emma-boyde

Jack Davies, Director, Producer (London)
Dir.JackDavies

Jennifer Jiles, Actor, Writer, Producer, Curveballs Series
Productions (New York)
<https://jenniferjiles.com/>

Jonah Kessel, Dep Dir
Opinion Video at The New York Times (New York)
Kessel@NYT / jonahkessel

Joanna Glushak
Broadway Actress (New York)
joannaglushak

JoAnna Mendl Shaw
Artistic Director of the The Equus Projects
(New York)
<https://www.equus-onsite.org/>

John Koutselinis, Composer Motion
Pictures (UK) johnkoutselinis

Jonathan Elliott, Dir, Journalist (London)
Elliott media

Juliet Linderman, Investigative Reporter, Associated
Press (Baltimore)

Justin Joseph Hall, Director & Editor, Fourwind Films
(Brooklyn, NYC)

Khalil Hanoun, Executive Producer - Film Critic Aljazeera (Doha,
Qatar)

Dr. Kenji Fujimura, Dir,
Int'l Academy of Musical Arts (Melbourne, Australia)
kenjimusic

Mark Schilling, Senior Film Critic at the Japanese Times (Tokyo)

Michael Santoro, Former Executive Chef, The Beverly Hills Hotel (Los Angeles)
mosaic

Miguel Cruz, Director, Film & TV (Los Angeles)
[miguelcruz](#) / [fastforward](#)

Nico Maounis, Head of Special News Events, The Americas - Associated Press (New York)

Phil Lavelle, Producer, Good Morning America (New York)

Salin Amin, Chairman at Camerapix (Kenya)
[Amin \(World Economic Forum\)](#)

Shelley Spadoni, Deputy Showbiz Editor, OK! New and Notebook
(London)
<https://www.ok.co.uk/>

Stephanie Rosenberg, Broadway Producer (New York)
[EmpressProductions](#)

Wade Shepard, Author, Writer, Filmmaker
(New York)

SPECIAL FEATURE: Jury Feedback for ALL Submitting Teams

One of the unique features of a grassroots inter-school film festival like this, is that we teachers want this sort of thing to be a positive learning experience for all young submitters.

Therefore, in THIS film festival, ALL submitting student production teams will receive both an official certificate of participation as well as written jury feedback, like the example provided from a previous COVID-19 Film Festival directed by Teacher Doug Hart.

Check Below

We believe that this type of substantive feedback will make our film festival special and personally valuable to all participating children and youth. Check below:

This photo is from a post.

View Post

COVID 19 International Student Film Festival
31 May 2020

JURY COMMENTS

MA: SECOND PLACE WINNER: HS FICTION
Director - Victoria Cheah 妈
High School - Fiction
Shanghai Singapore International School
Shanghai, China
https://youtu.be/xmdxa_Wa830

PAUL CHART

A very touching and nicely shot piece. Also well structured and complete. You're very talented - congratulations - keep shooting what you feel, and you'll always have a good job.
STEPHANIE ROSENBERG
You brought me to tears, this was so good, and deeply moving. Just Wow. Anyone who has ever lost someone they love would be moved. Great angles, great use of music, great continuity. Good use of the cross fades. Great editing and storytelling. Just Wow. Anyone who has ever lost someone they love would be moved.
TIM O'MARA
Strong narration with excellent imagery tells a very strong narrative of love in these turbulent times. Excellent message.
CATHERINE SCHREIBER
Really moving ode to Mom. You created a world of isolation as opposed to the world when the mother and daughter were together. Lovely scenes of the mom with the daughter. Scene composition and editing were excellent. Good music. Keep going! Beautiful film techniques. Clean, moving, nice shots. Nice editing. Good angle work. Excellent music... Nice split scene of then and now. Moving. Excellent. Natural. Felt

Tim O'Mara
London, UK
Film/TV Director

Amelia Campbell
NYC, NY
Broadway Actress

Shanghai Singapore International School

JURY COMMENTS
By Director Victoria Cheah

Kim Browning
Los Angeles
Dir. Hollywood Shorts

Shanghai China

Laushka Zadeh
London, UK
Film Critic, Metro

Miguel Cruz
Los Angeles
Filmmaker

Catherine Schreiber
NYC, NY
Broadway Producer

Guy Roberts
Prague, Czechia
CEO/Director/Actor
Prague Shakespeare

John Koutselinas
Stevenage, UK
Film Composer

Frankie Ramirez
NYC, NY
NBC Casting Director

Lilly Dawson
Los Angeles
Casting Director

Mike McCallih
Warwick, UK
Film Critic, Guardian

Carole Kirschner
Los Angeles
TV/Film Executive

Khalil Hanoun
Doha, Qatar
News/Doc Producer

Stephanie Rosenberg
NYC, NY
Broadway Producer

Paul Chart
Los Angeles
Film/TV Producer

Feedback Continues in the Right Column as You Scroll Down